LECTURE SERIES

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Names Have Been Changed

Book Talk & Signing

YU-MEI BALASINGAMCHOW

Author, MFA Boston University

with a conversation with Brown University Professor & Senior Associate Dean Zachary Sng

October 21, 2026
5:30 - 7 P.M.

Pembroke Center
Room 305

SYNOPSIS

SEASI

Ophir's tale begins in Singapore, where a petty crime spins out of control, estranging her from home and family. Resorting to false identities and forged passports (being mixed-race helps), she crisscrosses the globe from a Paris-themed hostess bar in Tokyo, to a bustling Chinese restaurant in London, to a snowbound mountain town in Colorado and beyond.

Broadcasting from an undisclosed location, Ophir is funny, prickly, tough, and vulnerable, entrancing her listeners with an irresistible, no-holds-barred recounting of not only her crimes (plural) but also her deepest secrets and regrets. Even as she moves seamlessly across class lines and continents, she grapples with the shock of relentless dislocation, a painful reexamination of identity, and a deep yearning for home. She tries to find comfort in new lovers and ill-gotten luxury goods, but she can't help attracting trouble, and she soon faces an unexpected, high-stakes choice that could change her fate forever.

Names Have Been Changed is a stylish, fast-paced debut novel that reveals the complicated paths we take to build a life and a home. Filled with danger and twists, it's ultimately a story about immigration and belonging—one unlike any you've seen before.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Yu-Mei Balasingamchow was born in Singapore and moved to Boston, where she was a bookseller at Papercuts Bookshop and where she teaches writing workshops at GrubStreet. Her short fiction has received a Pushcart Prize special mention and been shortlisted for the Commonwealth Prize. She has an MFA in Creative Writing from Boston University, and has received grants from the Elizabeth George Foundation, Sewanee Writers Conference, and Singapore's National Arts Council.